

Smriti Irani
Minister of Women and Child Development

GETTY IMAGES

FEEDING THE MOST NEEDY

The ministry is doggedly pursuing its campaign for the girl child and against malnutrition among children

By Sonali Acharjee

SPEAKING AT THE POSHAN 2.0 meet late last year in Gujarat's Kevadia, Smriti Irani, the minister for women and child development, said, "The responsibility of a well-nurtured India must be shared." The national conference saw the beginning of an initiative to reduce malnutrition—the first Child and Women Empowerment Forest, a patch of 151 nutrition-rich trees that would be the model for more such plantations across the country. Irani's push for such initiatives couldn't have been more well-timed, with the latest World Bank report indicating that India suffered a decline of 4 per cent in GDP due to malnutrition. "Since 2018, even in the midst of the Covid epidemic, a mass movement is going on against malnutrition by carrying out about 16 crore activities with public cooperation," Irani said. Indeed, her ministry ensured essential food items for children and pregnant mothers were distributed once every 15 days even during the lockdown.

A WCD ministry assessment of 10 million children from anganwadis found that around 7 per cent are malnourished and 2 per cent afflicted by severe acute malnutrition (SAM). While asserting that the number of SAM-affected children has "come down to 1 million from 8 million earlier", the ministry has been educating anganwadi workers on early identification and management of such children. Smartphones have been provided to such workers in 352 districts across 27 states, so that they can update the ministry's 'Poshan Tracker', which tracks preparation of meals for anganwadi children as well as the supply chain of rations.

For the protection of women from domestic abuse and other crimes, the ministry kept its helplines and one-stop centres running during the lockdown. The ministry's Sakhi dashboard helped real-time management of cases of violence-affected women. The ministry is also working on the Mahila Shakti Kendra scheme—an interface for rural women to access government entitlements.

The ministry also kept up awareness campaigns for Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao, leading to greater sensitisation on issues facing the girl child. In 2020, the sex ratio at birth went up to 934 from 931 the previous year.

But its work is far from over, as India continues to battle malnutrition among children and its women keep falling off the workforce. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- **Smartphones provided to workers in 352 districts in 27 states, covering around 641,000 anganwadi centres, to update Poshan Tracker**
- **Rs 2,500 crore allocated under PM Matru Vandana Yojana for DBT to bank accounts of pregnant mothers**
- **Instituted SHe-Box, an online platform for women to register workplace sexual harassment complaints**
- **Supported 6,374 media campaigns on Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao, and 52,240 training programmes for ASHA and anganwadi workers**

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **Tackling malnutrition as India continues to have one of the world's highest numbers of malnourished and stunted children, costing us an estimated 4% of GDP every year, per the World Bank**
- **Encourage more women in the workforce**